

By George, IT'S WAR

Claims and allegations multiply as the custody battle over the legendary socialist afflicted with Alzheimer's becomes a public drama starring wife, son, brothers and friends



LEILA AND GEORGE FERNANDES
WITH MARGARET ALVA AT BABA
RAMDEV'S ASHRAM IN HARDWAR

RAMESHWAR GAUR

By Priya Sahgal and Bhavna Vij-Aurora

Alzheimer's disease takes over the part of the brain that controls thought, memory and speech. For George Fernandes, this prison is even more stifling than the one he was incarcerated in during the 1970s. The fiery socialist, who once stopped trains, is now babbling incoherently, unable to walk without support. When Uttarakhand Governor Margaret Alva visited him at Baba Ramdev's ashram in Hardwar, she couldn't hold back her

tears on seeing the erstwhile firebrand playing with toy building blocks meant to improve the 79-year-old's eye-hand coordination.

Yet there is nothing childlike about the games that are being played with him. On one side are the former defence minister's wife Leila Kabir Fernandes and son Sean, while on the other there are Jaya Jaitly, his confidante, and his four brothers. He was brought to the ashram from 3, Krishna Menon Marg in New Delhi, his home for two decades, by his wife and son. There

are times when he wakes up at night, saying he has to go to Parliament. A car is brought, his briefcase put in, and he is driven around the ashram. It's a charade that has echoes of the one being played around him. Estranged for 25 years from his wife, he was always seen in public with his confidante and colleague Jaitly. Hence the recent return of his wife and US-based son as primary care-givers had its own share of drama. Fernandes's youngest brother Richard refers to their return as a "medieval palace coup".

When he was diagnosed with Alzheimer's in 2006, Jaitly took care